

IN CONTEXT**FOCUS****International law****BEFORE**

1899 The International Peace Conference at The Hague sets up the Permanent Court of Arbitration.

1920 The League of Nations sets up the Permanent Court of International Justice (PCIJ).

1944 The International Monetary Fund and the World Bank are set up at Bretton Woods, New Hampshire.

1944 At Dumbarton Oaks, Washington, DC, the Allies decide to establish the UN.

AFTER

1948 The UN issues the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

1992 The Earth Summit is held by the UN in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil.

When the United Nations (UN) Charter was signed in San Francisco in June 1945, World War II still had 3 months to run, and the nations that came together wanted to prevent such a terrible conflict happening again.

The UN Charter contained two fundamental pledges: first, that it would rid the world of “the scourge of war”; and second, that it would rebuild “faith in fundamental human rights.” The UN’s record in fulfilling those pledges has proved to be more checkered than hoped, but they remain core to its mission today—to preserve peace and human rights by international agreement and discussion and to solve disputes between nations—and between nations and individuals—by arbitration and legal process, not force of arms.

International cooperation

The UN’s most visible department is its international Peacekeeping Force, which aims to achieve the first of the UN’s five key targets—maintaining international peace and security. But peace very much depends on the UN’s success in its

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I believe at some future day, the nations of the Earth will agree on some sort of congress which will take cognizance of international questions of difficulty.

Ulysses S. Grant

18th US president (1869–1877)

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other four targets: to protect human rights, deliver humanitarian aid, promote sustainable development, and uphold international law. The UN also has a brief to strive to bring nations together to work toward these goals.

The beginning of international cooperation lay in the Hague Conventions of 1899 and 1907. The Hague peace conferences were the first real attempts by nations to come together and set agreed

Franklin D. Roosevelt

Born in New York in 1882, Franklin D. Roosevelt won four consecutive terms as US president. After first being elected in 1933, he is best known for implementing the New Deal program of public works to lift the US out of the Great Depression (1929–1933). However, he considered his most important work to have been laying the foundations of the United Nations (UN). FDR drafted the text of the Declaration by United Nations, which was signed by delegates from 26 nations in January 1942. It

pledged to jointly fight the Axis powers of Germany, Italy, and Japan.

Plans to create a new organization for international cooperation grew out of this agreement. In April 1945, FDR was working on a speech he planned to deliver at the UN Conference on International Organization (UNCIO) when he collapsed and died. The UNCIO, which opened less than 2 weeks after his death, agreed to establish the UN, and FDR’s wife Eleanor later helped draft its Declaration of Human Rights.